even debate with us as equals working for the nation (unlike the BJP, which sees them as enemies). I could clearly make out the difference that made our leadership stand out from the rest—it was the pure intent to understand and help Indian society. I am sure that most of these people who came for these interactions saw the Congress party in a whole new light largely because of these interactions. I think that's why lakhs of Marathi manush (people of Maharashtra) filled the streets and grounds, and we had celebrities from the film industry walking with commoners like brothers and sisters. The Maharashtra leg of the Yatra was filled with something magical that stayed with us.

On my part, I just felt fortunate for getting an intensive orientation on the key issues that Kerala and Maharashtra face. One of the conversations that has been etched into my soul forever was the one with intellectuals, poets and writers from across the state whom Rahul Gandhi asked to forge an alternative term to 'Dalit', since the connotation therein might be negatively construed. That conversation was very stimulating and thought-provoking.

In retrospect, the Yatra was a massive learning experience for me. The only constants in my life were my 3.30 a.m. alarm and a minimum of 25,000 daily steps on my pedometer. Everything else was completely dynamic. From the timely dissipation of information about the schedule the next day (kept confidential until hours before) and maintaining a constant dialogue with the media to coaxing essential information out of a few control-freak colleagues, fixing the venue, managing the daily press conferences, arranging one-on-one interviews, and escorting and accompanying the interviewees until it was over to avoid any unbecoming event, the chores kept adding up. Towards the end of my Yatra, I had even prepared a blue book for reference for others who would come after me, who could benefit from my learnings. To quote my immediate boss Pawan Khera's response when I wrote in to express my heartfelt gratitude, my only thought was: 'May our creed grow.'

I feel that the Yatra was a havan (sacred ritual) that was purging India's political space. And it was preparing each of us in the Yatra for this larger